

Cyber Warfare and the Iran War

Scope and Methodology

On February 28, 2026, the United States and Israel started striking targets within Iran beginning Operation Epic Fury. As of June 18th, the United States and Iran have signed an MOU agreeing to terms to end the war. At the time of publication, this agreement stands. The scope of this analysis will be limited to a handful of significant cyber-attacks from the start of the operation to the signing of the MOU. As with many combat operations, cyber operations are often kept out of the public eye creating limited opportunities to gather high confidence intelligence. Due to this, research primarily relied on open-source publications from private media outlets in the US and Middle East, threat intelligence feeds, and think tank reports. Assessments in this analysis are made with moderate confidence based on open-source reporting.

Cyber Warfare's Role in the Conflict

This conflict has given us insight into the role the digital domain plays in modern warfare and how it expands the reach of its combatants. During Operation Epic Fury all participants used cyber warfare to amplify their given strategies, with Iran primarily using its capabilities to demonstrate its global reach and the US-Israeli coalition as an instrument to pressure regime change.

One fascinating use of cyber warfare was the tactic of hacking domestic surveillance systems, specifically cameras, to conduct intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR). Regional and American media has claimed Israel abused Iran's internal surveillance systems to track the Ayatollah, providing valuable intelligence on a high value target at the start of the war.¹ ² Activity had also been observed on the Iranian side, confirming Iranian actors hacked cameras across the Middle East to monitor incoming strikes and to ensure their own strikes had been effective.³ The widespread adoption of the Internet of Things has enhanced combatants' ability to perform ISR remotely, reducing reliance on traditional espionage methods and increasing the role of cyber capabilities in modern combat. Both sides shared this benefit, but looking deeper we can see more unique cyber strategies at play.

The US-Israeli coalition stated its primary objective was regime change, and its cyber strategy supported this. Rather than relying on cyber warfare to cripple Iranian infrastructure or military capabilities, the US and Israel attacked the digital domain to spread anti-regime messaging. Prior to the outbreak of the war, Iran had experienced heavy protests which challenged the regime. US-Israeli psychological warfare may have sought to reignite this sentiment.

Iran adopted a defense model based on deterrence and pressure. Iran's goal was to prove it could create destruction and disruption on a global scale and pressure the US and Israel into permanent withdrawal. Primary methods included striking targets across the Gulf region, throttling global oil markets, issuing fatwas, and launching long-range missiles at previously unseen ranges. Iran sought to demonstrate reach as far beyond its borders as it could and used its cyber strategy to expand this by targeting American companies and infrastructure. The hacks discussed did not target groups which necessarily had a material impact on the conflict but rather showed an ability to reach out and touch its adversaries.

Iranian Strategy: Strategic Signaling

The Iranian cyber threat actor Handala Hack was perhaps the most significant piece of Iran's cyber warfare capabilities. Handala is regarded as an arm of Iran's Ministry of Intelligence and Security by multiple threat intelligence firms and government agencies, though the extent of operational involvement with the Iranian government is unclear. Whether acting independently or at the direction of the Iranian government, Handala's actions during the conflict supported Iran's strategic objectives.

On March 11th, the world-leading medical technology company Stryker suffered a massive cyber-attack, shutting down operations globally. Handala claimed responsibility for the attack, citing retribution for the US missile strike on an elementary school in Minab. Handala claimed to have exfiltrated 50TB of data, wiped over 200,000 corporate systems, and defaced internal login pages. Stryker confirmed the group had compromised administrative accounts and abused Microsoft Intune to remotely wipe, fill, and encrypt the disks of corporate devices rendering them unusable.⁴ The exact scope of the group's data exfiltration and wiper activity remains unverified.

More recently, on June 11th, Handala announced a breach of the California Water Service. The group claimed to have infiltrated the organization's networks but ensured not to disrupt any water distribution. Handala corroborated the claims by publicly posting customer information obtained from the service's billing platform.⁵ Investigations into the breach are ongoing and the water service has claimed the impacted billing systems are isolated from its operational systems.⁶ In both cases, it is likely Handala's initial claims were overstated but nonetheless some level of success was achieved.

US-Israeli Strategy: Psychological Warfare

The US and Israel's stated goal of the conflict was regime change. To aid this, their strategy appeared to be focused more on deploying cyber capabilities as a mode of information and psychological warfare. Most attacks observed here involved targeting media sources to

transmit anti-regime messages, encourage defection, and sow confusion among Iranian forces and civilians alike.

A great example of this strategy is the BadeSaba prayer app hack. BadeSaba Calendar is a popular Shia prayer app with millions of downloads in Iran. A primary function of the app is sending push notifications to users with prayer reminders, which is specifically what the attack exploited.⁷ On February 28th, immediately at the start of the conflict, the app transmitted anti-regime messages to its users' devices in Farsi. The messages warned that reckoning had come and encouraged IRGC forces to lay down their arms. The Jerusalem Post also reported Iranian state television networks were hacked to transmit anti-regime media including a message from the ousted Reza Pahlavi, calling on the IRGC to take the side of protestors.⁸ Iran dealt with these breaches with broad shutdowns of internet connectivity in attempts for containment.

These events show how both kinetic and cyber capabilities may be used in a multi-vectored approach to further strategic objectives. In both attack examples, the digital medium was one of high trust and high adoption in Iranian society meaning its reach was maximum. It also forced Iran to implement internet shutdowns which in turn impacted its own cyber operations.⁹

Implications for Private Industry

Private industry has always been a target in wars due to the resources and capabilities it provides for its nation(s). Modern digitization has drastically changed the risk landscape though and organizations need to recognize this new reality. Digital attack vectors provide cyber threat actors with a myriad of new ways to bring down a company's operations for the sake of battlefield effects or simply ideology. The more internet-connected devices a company has on its network the more possible access points an attacker has.

Companies need to be prepared to prevent becoming a headline. Cyber defense teams need to be equipped to detect and respond early to potential threat actor behaviors. Business continuity teams need to create or update plans to quickly recover from cyber-attacks. Employee populations need to be adequately educated on cyber risks to ensure strong security hygiene. C-Suite executives need to realize the reality of this new threat environment and enable their organizations to take the necessary steps to build effective programs.

Takeaways

The Iran War is a case study of how cyber warfare can be used in modern conflicts. There are certainly more examples from the war which weren't touched on here; however, the information presented paints a picture of an Iranian desire to create global effects and a US-Israeli desire to influence popular opinion within Iran. Even when considering additional

examples this article did not touch on, takeaways can be boiled down to recognizing how drastically modern battlefields have expanded with the digital domain. Battlefields are no longer constrained to the distance kinetic forces can reach but now to the distance digital packets can reach - which is everywhere.

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